from the media and individuals from the private sector; he conducted another round of video conferences. His message was clear: to create awareness and prepare the people for a wave without instilling panic or fear. He requested them to issue continuous reminders on following COVID-19-appropriate behaviour and exercise caution. Aware of the increased fatality of the circulating variants, he also began to make calls to senior citizens including those from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) family to enquire about their health and safety. For him, it was a way of connecting with his extended family and people who he had spent time with decades back. According to the prime minister, in conversations, his seniors not only gave him their blessings, but also feedback on what was happening in society and in their personal lives. This warmth is what kept him going in the tough times.

On 4 April, in a high-level meeting at the PMO which was attended by Principal Secretary Dr Mishra, Cabinet Secretary Rajiv Gauba, Dr Paul, Mr R.S. Sharma, PSA VijayRaghavan, Secretaries of Home, Health, Pharmaceuticals, Biotechnology, AYUSH and Dr Bhargava, the prime minister showed concern towards the alarming rate of growth of new cases. Maharashtra was contributing 57 per cent of all cases in the country, and Punjab and Chhattisgarh were contributing 16.3 per cent and over 7 per cent of all deaths in a seven-day average, respectively. It was especially concerning that the death rates were so high in Punjab and Chhattisgarh. In addition to these three states, seven others were contributing to more than 91 per cent of all new cases in the country. The prime minister asked, ‘Why is the death rate so high in Punjab and Chhattisgarh? If one state is contributing more than half of the total cases of the country, we must investigate why along with sending them whatever help they require. Let us send central teams of public health specialists and clinicians to Maharashtra, Punjab and Chhattisgarh for assistance. For sustainable COVID-19 management, *jan bhagidari* is absolutely crucial; people’s involvement at every level is paramount! For this, we must run a special campaign from April 6th to 14th for a week which will emphasize on 100 per cent mask usage, personal hygiene and sanitation.’ The team informed him that although at this point the exact correlation between the mutant strains and the growth of cases could not be ascertained, the sharp rise could also be attributed to COVID-19 fatigue, a decline in compliance of COVID-19-appropriate behaviour and lack of implementation of